



From the album: Rachael Heyhoe Flint, captain of host England in the inaugural Women's World Cup in 1973, with the participating teams outside 10 Downing Street, London. **Below:** Mithali Raj (second from right) captained India in the 2005 edition, leading the team to the final. GETTY IMAGES

edition with Australia, attributes this to a fresh outlook on the PowerPlay — yet another gift of the T20 era.

"If you rewind maybe even 10 years ago, the mantra was to survive the PowerPlay, keep wickets in hand, and then slowly you can build and cash in at the end. I heard Beth Mooney and Kim Garth say that the third ODI felt like T20 cricket for 100 overs. That's how they were playing it as well," she tells *Sportstar*.

Cover all bases

What also helps is an increasing homogenisation of wickets around the world.

"If you're not familiar with the background in a particular venue and switch the television on and look at a strip, you won't potentially know where the game is played. The character of the pitch is more or less standardised, as the ICC says," Raman notes.

Sthalekar also brushes off conjectures of predominantly spin-friendly conditions in the subcontinent. "I don't think India is creating those dust bowls anymore. I think they're creating opportunities for fast bowlers," she underlines. "The pitches are providing a little bit more pace, good carry, which is effective.

The theory that Indian pitches are dust bowls is coming from people who may have looked at the game 10 years ago."

This transition has bloomed along with the demands of the game. A potent pace pool was earmarked as top of the Indian wishlist, right from Raman's time through to when Amol Muzumdar took charge of the setup.

The Jhulan Goswami-sized gap (post her retirement) triggered a panic to find the next pace-bowling sensation. Several players have entered the musical chairs for the role, but injury (think Pooja Vastrakar), lack of faith from management (Shikha Pandey), or gaps in skill mean India doesn't have the ideal candidate yet. While still a work in progress, focused national camps and the seam demands created by the Women's Premier League have helped India advance down this path.

While India works on its teething troubles in pace, the rest of the world has attempted to catch up in the spin-bowling game. England, whose bowling annals boast ruthless seamers like Katherine Sciver-Brunt and Anya Shrubsole, comes into this World Cup with a top-notch spin quartet. Australia has always been ahead of the curve, carrying quality tweakers who thrive in subcontinent conditions. Spin still keeps India ahead, even if barely, with Deepti Sharma leading the bowlers' chart for this cycle with 59 scalps.

What India will draw confidence from is the healthy crop of youngsters making their opportunities count. In pacer Kranti Goud and spinner N. Shree Charani, the WPL has gifted the national team two adaptable, spunky players who are happy to take aggression to the opponent. That India has chosen to take a punt on them, like it has with Pratika Rawal at the top of the order at the expense of Shafali, signals a welcome change in perspective. "Thank God for that," Raman chuckles. "It's not always about how long you've been playing this game. It's good that they are not really taking decisions based on a predetermined stance and they are looking at who are the ones who are likely to serve a team well in a

